

When do you need to do impact evaluation rather than just measure high-level outcome indicators?

This When Impact Evaluation Is Needed Rather Than Just Measuring Outcomes Indicators Explainer (G3) is used to show that just measuring that high-level not-necessarily controllable indicators (typically called 'outcomes') have improved does not prove an initiative made them improve. This is described as the outcomes not being 'attributable' to the initiative. The explainer uses three components from the DoView Planning Framework (D1) to highlight this point.

Looking at the explainer and imagining a left-to-right strategy/outcomes diagram, the indicators with an '@' sign in Component D are controllable by the agency, provider, policy or initiative.

In a case where these controllable indicators reach right up to the top of the DoView strategy/outcomes diagram, there is no attribution problem, and therefore, there is less need for impact evaluation (Component H). This is because merely measuring that controllable indicators (from Component D) have occurred proves that it is the organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative that has made them occur. This is because they are controlled by the initiative. In other words, they would not have occurred if the initiative had not made them happen.

However, in the case of indicators without an '@' sign in Component E, because they are 'not-necessarily controllable' by the initiative, merely measuring that they have occurred does not prove that it is the initiative that has made them happen. The only way to prove that these not-necessarily controllable indicators are attributable to the initiative is by using one or more of the impact evaluation designs set out in the impact evaluation component (Component H).

You can use this explainer to make the point that just measuring that high-level outcomes have occurred does not prove that it is the initiative that has made them happen. If you want to prove attribution where controllable indicators are not high enough, you need to use impact evaluation (Component H) to prove that the initiative is having an attributable impact on high-level not-necessarily controllable indicators.